

An impossible dream?

IN THIS ISSUE, WE'RE DARING TO DREAM OF A FUTURE WHERE POLITICIANS OF THE WORLD TAKE A HARD CALL, and stand up to some of their biggest donors, or even stand against some companies that essentially rule the narrative of the world. Why? To support your rights as a consumer, and to finally show with meaningful action that they actually give a \$hit about the planet, by legislating against rampant consumerism.

In moments of clarity (or when reality bites) I realise that the Right to Repair (RR) dream might just remain a dream. The economies of the richest countries rely on people buying new stuff, and no one wants a politician that ruins an economy, even if they do it for the right reason.

It's not just the RR movement that seems an impossible dream, but truly modular devices that are actually completely customisable by buyers. No matter how awesome I think such devices would be, most people just want something that is simple and works. We really do not want to get our hands dirty when it comes to assembling things, or tweaking code or setting up devices from scratch to be "designed" by us, and more importantly, unique!

In the cover story you will see one such device mentioned – Framework (<https://framework.com>) – which is a really easy to repair laptop that you can customise and upgrade just as you would a desktop. Not mentioned in the cover story is the Fairphone, which is a mobile phone designed along the same lines as the Framework laptop. The idea is that instead of buying a new phone every year because of camera improvements, you could just buy an upgraded camera, swap out the older one, and install a newer model, and voila, a software update later you'd ready to shoot far better photographs with almost the same phone that you already have.

Most often, people shy away from such products because they don't want to, or cannot, open up devices and swap out components. The other bit is the whole thrill of buying a new product, which looks different and new, and boasts of some new feature, or new colour, or new form factor... all of this, of course, makes the option of having the same boring old phone seem ridiculous.

If you care about the environment, and are against child labour or the exploitation of the poor, then it makes total sense to buy gadgets that will last you for a long time. Not just that, in the case of the Fairphone, for example, the phone itself is built out of mainly recyclable material, and iFixit scored it 10/10 for repairability. Still, barely anyone will buy it. Because we cannot imagine having a phone for more than 3 years, can we?

Until we discover something new in material science, it will always be hard to make a modular design that looks anywhere close to as good as the flagship phones from almost all brands. So do we give up? Of course not. The cover story has poked fun at my old Ericsson GH 337 mobile phone. Why? Because I sing praises of the phone and how hardy it was. Truthfully though, it was just a really simple design, had very few parts, and was not really competing with the supermodel like thinness of modern phones. Would I buy that phone again? For nostalgia sure, to actually use? No way!

We're going to need sci-fi like material science to come in and find answers to questions we didn't even know we were supposed to ask! Metals that can be easily manipulated, and which turn from hard metal shells to soft TPU like material just by applying some charge, or physical pressure, etc. Imagine metals that flow like liquids or foam at room temperature, allowing you to mold just about any shape for your device. Imagine the amount of creativity that would happen at such events!

Some of this futuristic material might take the form of super thin sheets of graphene, bendable batteries, carbon nanotubes, or even metal foam. Metallic glass could put gorilla glass to shame, because it would be orders of magnitude stronger, and transparent alumina is something along the same lines. It might not be artificial stuff at all but biological computing done by living cells (DNA computing but on steroids!).

The point I'm trying to make is that while in the short term finding a way to uphold our rights to repair and make our gadgets last, whilst still remaining on the cutting edge of tech, and also not harming the environment is an impossible dream, that's exactly what people from 30 years ago would have said about the technology that we take for granted today! 🇺🇸



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